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To Whom it May Concern,

What does it mean to be a great software engineer? Surprisingly in my experience it has little to do with actually writing code, and now with AI even less so. It doesn't really have to do with solving problems because often we forget to check if it's a problem we have or the user has. To me great software engineering never forgets why it is there, to help someone, and to do that you have to communicate and listen.

When you've been in the industry as long as I have you learn a lot of things, but the main thing I have learned is the importance of communication. It doesn't matter how good your code is, or your interface if it doesn't solve the problems real users have. You can see this in my experience with Conductor, simply meeting with clientele more often listening and asking questions, we as a team were able to see a giant hole in the workflow and implement tools to fix them and generate more traffic. Time and time again the power of clear honest communication has won out over just writing code.

As an Engineer that thinks good design is a vital part of communicating to the user, and enabling them to use our data or awesome algorithms to their full potential, I have chosen to focus on user interfaces. But unlike most frontend engineers I think the user doesn't just start and end with the clientele, but I also consider myself and fellow engineers users, users that interface with the code we use. As such I have also spent a large portion of my time making the engineering tools we use easier to wrangle. From helping at conductor with a sandbox implementation for our custom ui toolkit so it can be properly tested (enabling engineers to know definitively if it was their code, or the toolkits code malfunctioning), to pushing for and implement continuous deployment and testing (allowing for better planning, and a boost in productivity), I have experienced first hand if you don't give people their proper tools things won't get done.

Communication is the hardest thing to do, and takes many forms, the most important one is communication of teams. There is something to learn from everyone, and often when there are many smart people in the room with valid opinions the most important part of moving forward is finding the common ground so everyone can get excited about what is being built.

I believe that a good software engineer should work themselves out of a job because they are so good at it, that everything has been documented and made easy even for those without much technical knowledge. If you're looking for someone that can fit anywhere, and is resilient in the face of uncertainty, and ambiguity that has the mindset that anything is possible with time and effort, I am your man.

Thanks,
Khalah Jones Golden